

TABLET PCS

The latest buzz in mobile computing are tablet PCs. The concept conceived by software giant Microsoft, and these devices are a cross between palm tops and laptops. A tablet PC allows you a palmtop-like input facility via a stylus and the touch sensitive LCD screen. Tablets are often used in hospitals, where the doctor can access prescription data of a particular patient while taking rounds, or in manufacturing and construction sites to glance quickly through any required information.

Such work places demand devices that are portable and can be handled comfortably. Dimensions, weight and configuration

Acer C110

Baby's day out

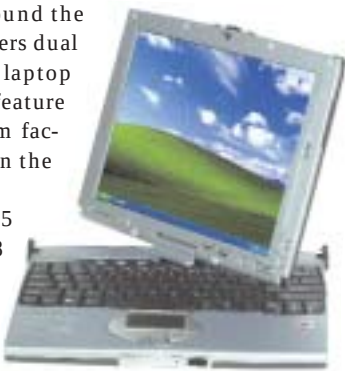
The Acer C110 is built around the convertible idea, and offers dual functionality as both a laptop and a tablet. Its most striking feature is the amazingly compact form factor. This was the cutest device in the comparison.

The C110 weighs a mere 1.5 Kgs and measures 25 x 21 x 28 cms, making it the lightest and smallest tablet in the comparison. It may be small, but in no way is it underpowered. The 10-inch LCD display is clear and crisp with a good viewing angle. It has a Pentium M 900 MHz processor but comes with 512 MB of DDR RAM to make up for the low-processor speed. Despite the small size, Acer manages to cram in a 40 GB hard disk, and as it runs on the Centrino platform, it also offers wireless connectivity.

The keyboard is comfortable as it is arc-shaped. The keys are small, but comfortable, and have good tactile feedback. The touchpad is small and quite cumbersome to use. To change to the tablet mode, you need to unlock the clamps holding the screen on the sides, and twist it and fold it flat. The locking mechanism for the screen is quite flimsy. The hotkeys are perfectly placed within easy reach of your fingers, as is the stylus.

The C110 showed signs of being under-powered in the CPU and hard disk tests. However, the memory subsystem is excellent—it beat the Toshiba 3500's SD-RAM subsystem convincingly. The graphics performance was certainly the best amongst the lot, courtesy the latest generation on-board graphics by Intel.

At Rs 1,59,990, the Acer C110 is better priced than the Toshiba tablet. Only its no-so-elegant looks and flimsy build quality were disappointing, but at such a good price, it is the better option.



Acer C110		C
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Usability	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	

Price: Rs 1,59,990
+ Extremely portable, good configuration
- Needs a better build quality

are the factors that determine the cost of a Tablet. There are currently two types of tablet PCs available: the stand-alone models that are true tablets, and the convertibles. This can also masquerade as a laptop. The weight of these devices is usually between 1.5 Kgs to 2.5 Kgs. The true tablets have no moving parts and are robust, the apparent mechanical complexity of the convertibles makes them delicate gadgets. One more aspect that makes tablets different from laptops is the use of smaller LCD displays—12-inch displays are the norm.

ACi Tablet

The elephant ballet

This convertible tablet PC from ACi is like a pickup truck—massive, relatively ugly and slow. The tablet weighs around 2.5 Kg and measures a bulky 315 x 260 x 30 cms. The LCD display measures a full 14-inches, which is considered monstrous for a Tablet PC. With such dimensions and weight, the very purpose of a tablet seems to be lost.

Aesthetically, the steel grey finish and the chrome lining make the product look cheap. The interior has black keys and dark grey panels, contrasting with the pool of chrome and grey plastic.

Ergonomically, the keyboard is well spaced out and comfortable. The shortcut buttons for the tablet mode are placed on the sides. You have to get used to them and know exactly where each one is, before they even begin to be 'shortcut' keys.

The ACi tablet has a VIA Nehemiah 1 GHz processor, with 256 MB of RAM, a measly 20 GB hard disk and an onboard SiS adapter as the graphics card. The tablet comes with just two USB ports—all legacy ports are missing. However, other features such as flash memory card reader, external USB DVD-ROM, external floppy drive and compact flash reader are provided.

Via processors have weak FPU's, and the pathetic FPU score in the Sisoft Sandra CPU test and below par gaming benchmarks proved that. It was the lowest scorer of all in the Business Winstone test. Moreover, ACi does not bundle Windows XP Tablet Edition, making us wonder why they called it a tablet in the first place.

Though it's priced at just Rs 69,990, you'll have to shell out extra to get a tablet edition OS. The ACi Tablet is cheap, looks the part and absolutely fails to deliver where it matters.



ACi Tablet		A
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Usability	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	

Price: Rs 69,990
+ Large screen
- Poor performance, quite bulky